The Original Last Wish Baby

By William Seebring

DOCTOR: No heart? Good Heavens, that's impossible.
NURSE: Check for yourself, Doctor. [The DOCTOR extends his stethoscope into the crib.] DOCTOR: Nothing, no pulse. Not a sound. And yet, this baby clearly mimics life. A freak.
NURSE: A miracle. . . the baby is a miracle.
DOCTOR: A miracle? This is Cleveland. It'll be a miracle if the mother's insured.

INTRODUCTION

The Original Last Wish Baby, as researched, recorded and revised by William Seebring. Cleveland, Ohio. Or, more specifically, the third-floor maternity room of the Holy Name Hospital on Cleveland's impoverished west-side where, at precisely seven-oh-one P.M. A baby was born. Not just any baby, but the infamous, original, Last Wish Baby. The baby born without a heart.

NARRATOR: Not only were the baby's parents uninsured, the identity of the baby's father was unknown. However, the birth mother's name was given as Welda Mae Forms, a thirty-one-year-old unemployed cosmetologist. At the time, little else was known about Ms. Forms but word of her remarkable progeny spread quickly from the maternity ward to the scrub rooms to the hospital's administrative offices where a larger picture began to emerge.

EXECUTIVE: A baby born without a heart? Sounds awful. Sounds really awful.
ASSISTANT: Maybe not as bad as you think.
EXECUTIVE: C'mon Chet, how the hell do ya' window dress a missing heart? God knows we've had our share of high-risk deliveries here at Holy Name-little baby heads get smushed, tiny baby limbs get... it's messy, terrible, makes me shudder. But delivering a baby and not the heart-good God! [Beat.] What's our liability on something like that?
ASSISTANT: Well here's the thing, sir. . . the baby is alive. The baby is fully functioning, quite spirited and has a healthy appetite I might add. Its short life could, with the right spin, be played out as the most incredible P.R. story of our time. What's more, the timing couldn't have been more. . . fortuitous. . . sir. A miracle. . . and it happened here, in our hospital,

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under the care and guidance of our health care professionals. Think of it sir, Holy Name, the get-well place where miracles happen.

EXECUTIVE: Good boy. Oh, one other thing. . . the heart? Did anyone ever find the heart?

ASSISTANT: No. Actually, as far anyone knows, there never was a heart.

NARRATOR: In point of fact, there was a heart. However, through one of those unfathomable anomalies which defy all logic, yet govern most things, the heart was delivered separately by a surprised New Jersey woman on her way home from the store.

[Lights up on MS. SYDNEY KORNFELD, as she crosses the stage. She is walking past a MAN when something like a beef-steak tomato falls from her skirt. MS. KORNFELD continues on, unmindful.]

MAN: Yo, Miss. . . Ma'am! You dropped something. .*[MS. KORNFELD stops, turns and looks back.]*

MS. KORNFELD: Oh-my-god, what is it! *[Lights dim on MS. KORNFELD as she bends to retrieve the heart.]*

NARRATOR: That something would later be determined to be the baby's heart. However, at that particular moment, the New Jersey woman, later identified as Ms. Sydney Kornfeld, and who would soon become known as "The Baby Heart Mom," was not yet aware of the miracle baby story unfolding in Cleveland. As for Ms. Kornfeld, she fortuitously retrieved the baby heart and returned immediately to her home in Paramus where, as the demonstrator shall faithfully recreate, she placed the pulsating vital organ into a clear, air-tight, number-seven tupperware container, which she then filled with a high-fructose, low sodium, heavy-syrup drained from a can of Libby's yellow-cling sliced peaches. After burping for a tight seal, Ms. Kornfeld placed the container in the crisper drawer of her refrigerator where, according to product designers, the heart could have been stored indefinitely and would remain every bit as fresh and vigorous as the moment she delivered it.

REPORTER: But, what about the baby's mom? I'd like to hear her side of the story. I'd like to ask her a few questions.

ASSISTANT: Uh, well, actually-that's impossible. I'm sorry, we're just, she's just-she's in recovery right now.

NARRATOR: In fact, Welda Mae Forms was not in recovery. The so-called Baby Mom was not only alert and well-rested, she was, much to the dismay of hospital

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staffers, quite lucid and most out-spoken.

WELDA: What's with the seat belts! And where's my kid! I come into this dump to pop off another slug, which is the last thing I need, and you-all got me tied down so I can't even see Oprah!

EXECUTIVE: Ms. Forms, please, please calm down. There's something we have to tell you.

WELDA: What, is my baby dead, or deformed, or something?

ASSISTANT: Ub, well, Miss Forms, actually, it's more than that.

WELDA: Huh? Was that a hard question or are you really as stupid as you look? Listen here lap-dog, tell your fat boss that as far as I'm concerned I could care less if the little maggot's dead or mutated-hell, I never wanted one tuh begin with. Tried to have it flushed out in one of them clinics but them bible-thumpers chased me away and SO, I figured I'd drown the slug in booze. Well, did it work or what?

ASSISTANT: This is insane. We can't put that before the public. She'll ruin everything!

NARRATOR: Meanwhile, at that very moment, the afternoon press conference was being fed via satellite to network studios in New York. And news it was. "Within the hour, satellite-beaming reporters from around the world had descended on Cleveland like the plague and every last one of them wanted one thing-a baby mom exclusive. Hospital officials acted with both haste and prudence.

CLARA: Hello, Ms. Forms. My name is Clara Collins, I've been hired to be your image consultant.

NARRATOR: Clara Collins proved she was worth every penny of her hefty fee. In short order, Ms. Welda Mae Forms was polished, enlightened and coiffured. At long last, cameras were admitted into her room and a nation known for its thirst of spectacle, tuned in.

WELDA: [Her hands folded as if in prayer.] With the Lord's help, my precious, precious baby will live. Of course, I can't begin to thank all you wonderful little people out there who have kept me and my baby in your thoughts and prayers. Bless you. Bless you all.

NARRATOR: With that one newsbit, the groundswell of public emotion became unquenchable. Overnight, Cleveland's miracle tot became America's most adored critical-list baby. There were news conferences every morning and afternoon and updates on the baby's condition flashed every hour on the

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hour, but it wasn't enough. Americans not only wanted to know more, they wanted to know what more they could do . . .

CUSTOMER #2: And they say that baby could die any moment.

CUSTOMER #1: Hate to see that baby die and me not knowing if they was something I coulda' done.

CUSTOMER #2: Can't give baby my heart. But I'd give that baby anything else. Anything a'tall.

CUSTOMER #1: Say, you know I hear baby likes to watch big time wrestling! What say we call the hospital and see if we could buy that baby a brand new color TV! Now wouldn't that make us all feel a whole sight better?

NARRATOR: Calls from like-minded Americans jammed the hospital's switch-board. It was reported that in a single, twenty-four hour period more than twenty thousand color TV's were bought and delivered. Corporate America stood up and took note. Syndicate giant, GLAM ENTERTAINMENT, culled their best minds and put forward a most alluring concept.

GE PITCHMAN: Every night we'll feature the baby mom, Welda Mae Forms. We get her and we call it, "The Last "Wish Baby Show." See, every night mom stands in front of the camera holding little baby no-heart in her arms like this and she's pouting 'cause the doc's are telling her how the baby's supposed to die any minute but, and here's the kicker, before baby goes, baby's made this one last wish. . . get it? Baby's last wish- Last Wish Baby!

NARRATOR: A deal was proffered and quickly struck with Ms. Forms and her people. That very night, "The Last Wish Baby Show" blew out the ratings board with a whopping 75 share. Even more notable, the show's seamless tie-in with corporate sponsors set an industry standard.

WELDA: Poor, poor baby. Baby doesn't have a heart. Doctors say baby might have to leave us all for Heaven any minute now.[we hear the baby cry.] What's that Baby. . . ? [After leaning in to the baby, WELDA returns her gaze to the cameras.] Awww. Baby wishes some nice person out there would buy us a uh . . . a Sony XRK-35 Digital Game System.

NARRATOR: Meanwhile, in a certain kitchen in Paramus, New Jersey, a certain Guatemalan cleaning woman was wiping down a certain refrigerator when she made an unusual discovery.

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WOMAN: Eeeeee! Mios Dios! Eeeee!

KORNFELD: What? Que? Que esta? What the hell is it?

WOMAN: Nino! Nino con last wish! Nino con last wish!

KORNFELD: Baby? You mean that baby? That Last Wish baby? The one on TV? Give me that! [Studies the heart for a moment.] Oh-my-God, it's alive! I have the baby heart! What should I do? What should I do?

WOMAN: Llama de medico! Pronto! Pronto!

KORNFELD: Call a doctor?! Are you crazy? This is big, really big! I'm calling Howard Stern!

NARRATOR: Ms. Kornfeld's call to the popular radio shock jock was quickly put through and she revealed that she possessed what she believed was the Last Wish Baby's Heart. Meanwhile, word of the whereabouts of the newly discovered baby heart spread fast and a race, of sorts, was on. EMS crews were first on the scene but no sooner had they readied the baby heart for shipment to Cleveland when. . . the lawyers arrived. Motions were made. Injunctions issued. Larger questions loomed. The battle for custody of the Last Wish Baby had begun. The hearing to determine the rightful custodial parents of The Last Wish Baby had barely opened when legal fees threatened to exceed even Ms. Welda Mae Forms' recently fatted purse-strings. However, with the baby show still posting record ratings, Ms. Forms saw fit to make full use of her forum.

WELDA: [Angelic.] Poor, poor precious baby. Baby doesn't have a heart. . . know why? Hmmm? [Bitter.] 'Cause some East Coast floozy has got it and won't hand it over unless I give her half a' baby's royalties on the [The baby cries. WELDA looks down.] Yeah, what is it? [A beat to compose herself] Awww, but of course, baby. [WELDA looks up again and com poses herself] Baby wishes there was some nice, pro-bono law firm out there who would take Baby's rightful mother's custody case, and when that was all settled, and a certain individual from a certain so-called Garden-State was financially ruined, that same nice law firm might just be retained to negotiate with those shysters at Glum Entertainment for a more favorable contract. . . idn't that what baby wants? Yes, baby's so sweet. I just hope and pray this won't be baby's last wish.

NARRATOR: But, no sooner had Welda Mae and her people retained new legal counsel than a shocking courtroom revelation hit the newsstands.

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NEWSBOY: Read all about it! "Last Wish Baby Show" Hoax! Read all about it!

NARRATOR: Unsealed court documents alleged that the "Last Wish Baby Show" Baby was not the real Last Wish Baby, the baby born without a heart, but rather, a sixteen-year-old unemployed actor with a glandular condition. Americans shuddered. Did this mean the Original Last Wish Baby was dead? Or, Heaven forbid, was there even an original Last Wish Baby in the first place? Congressional spouses convened a hearing and demanded answers.

ASSISTANT: Okay, look, it was all my fault. I agreed to pull the baby from the show and I was the one who okayed it when the Forms woman wanted to hire [a stand-in]. But I only went along with it 'cause the doctors insisted on keeping the baby in intensive care. That's the God's-honest truth. There really is a Last Wish Baby, there really is a baby without a heart! I can prove it! I swear to God, I can prove it!

NARRATOR: Needless to say, Americans were skeptical and demanded that proof. Thus, the following night, "The Last "Wish Baby Show" aired live from the Holy Name Hospital's pediatric intensive care unit. Viewers held their breath as the Baby Mom ushered the cameras toward the swinging doors which led to Baby's chamber.

WELDA: Shhhh. Be quiet. This way, please.
ASSISTANT: Watch it, he's got a gun!

NARRATOR: Four shots, each one following its own fatal trajectory, were fired into the torso and cranial cavity of the woman most Americans knew only as the Last Wish Baby Mom. The assailant was identified as Daryl Wayne Trebleu, a slope-shouldered, itinerant floral designer from nearby Loraine, Ohio, and, purportedly, the man many believed to be the Last Wish Baby Dad. Daryl Wayne Trebleu never uttered a single word in his own defense. Rather, he expressed himself through artfully-designed floral arrangements. Mr. Trebleu's "Not competent to stand trial bouquet" was a lovely and eloquent display of mums, gladiolus, and forty-four magnum shell casings set in a handsome earthenware bowl. Meanwhile, in another court in another state, the judge in the custody hearing for the Last Wish Baby had reached a verdict.

JUDGE: As per the dictates of the honorable State of New Jersey, court of Domestic Relations, I have found as follows: Said infant, here-in-and-ever-

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after known as, "The Original Last Wish Baby," shall be granted ward status of this court, and thereby ordered to be joined immediately with heart. So be it, so help us God.

NARRATOR: With the Last Wish Baby Show having been abruptly pulled from the airwaves, no effort was made to appeal the Judge's decision. Thus, a medical team of the nation's leading cardio-vascular surgeons were assembled to carry out the court's wishes and, with God's blessing, prolong the baby's life. We take you now live, directly to the Hoppscotch Medical Center in Tarmack, New Jersey.

SURGEON: The operation to implant the baby heart into the Last Wish Baby was both... a success and... a failure. The heart was successfully sutured and continues to pump vigorously. Unfortunately, the baby, for reasons we do not fully understand, has ceased all other life sustaining functions and. . . appears to be in a rapid state of. . . decay.

NARRATOR: There was no denying it. The Original Last Wish Baby, the baby born without a heart, was now, and irretrievably, a dead baby, but one with a very healthy heart. And that presented doctors and lawyers with an entirely new set of problems. For one, the baby could not be considered legally dead unless the heart were either stopped or removed. However, if the baby was not legally dead, then removing or stopping the heart would be, in a word, murder. Therefore, despite all appearances to the contrary, the Last Wish Baby was, in the eyes of the law, very much alive. Further, this being a democratic society, it didn't take long for Americans to gaze upon their own dearly departed loved ones and find similar cause to stretch the definition of what constitutes life. . . and death. Suddenly, Americans became embroiled in an entirely new moral debate-when did life end? The question was not at all as simple as it sounded. After all, who in this country can say with any real certainty when life begins?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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